4 I choose to use a 15mm four-prong drive as it's small enough to stay out of my way and only leaves a tiny area to clean up at the end when holding the pieces of fruit in the jam chuck. In the tailstock a standard single pointed revolving centre is used; again this will leave only a small point to clean up at the end

5 Now to start the turning. Start by roughing down using a 20mm spindle roughing gouge and remember that, because the corners have been cut from the blank before mounting on the lathe, the toolrest can stay in position

6 Once roughed down, start the shape of the blank. Use a 10mm bowl gouge for this over a spindle gouge as it has far more structural strength and means you can cut right into the centres without chatter occurring. The shape is up to you. We all have in our minds the perfect shape for a piece of fruit, but don't get caught up too much in this. I think the best thing to do is to look at cartoon apples and pears – and not real ones – which will give you nice rounded shapes

7 Once you have turned the main shapes, finish as tight as you can to the centres by using a 3mm parting tool and side scraping, blending in the shape as you go

8 At this point you can look to sand to a finish. The grades I use for most pieces are as follows: first, 100 grit, which is the hardest working and needs to be used until all turning lines and/or torn grain have been removed. Then use the following order: 150, 240, 400, 600. This may seem to be a large jump, but works on most timbers. If you're struggling to get rid of the sanding lines, however, add in a 320 and sand for longer on each grade

9 When all signs of sanding have been removed, give the piece a coat of sanding sealer. I prefer to use cellulose sealer diluted 50/50 with cellulose thinners as this means the sealer will soak in a long way and cut through any oily timbers to seal in the grain. When the sealer has been applied just wipe off the excess; there's no need to do any further sanding or burnishing at this stage as the abrasive polish will do this for us at the later stages

10 When all your pieces of fruit have had their outside shape turned and sanded, it's time to use the jam chuck. Here I'm using a set of large jaws to hold the jam chuck

11 Gently offer the first piece of fruit into the chuck using a piece of beech dowel as a guiding rod and a knock-out bar. Slightly soften the contact end of the dowel with some abrasive so the rod won't damage the fruit it's knocking out. Gently tap in your first piece of fruit – a single tap should be enough as continued tapping may split your chuck or make your piece of fruit get stuck

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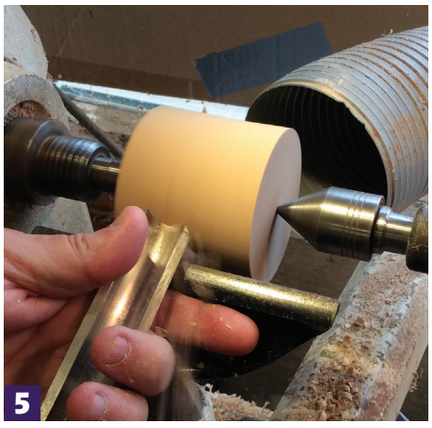
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